

Asking for and giving advice

Learner workbook

Ask a focused question and offer a useful option.

Understand the distinction

Give enough context for the listener to understand the problem. State your goal or constraint, then ask a specific question: I have ten minutes. Which route would you suggest? Advice is normally uncountable: some advice, a piece of advice.

When responding, offer an option and a reason. Could can present a possibility; should can make a stronger recommendation. Ask a clarifying question when information is missing. Acknowledge limits rather than giving confident advice on something you do not know.

Compare the patterns

CONTEXT

I need to reach the station by nine.

State the goal and constraint.

QUESTION

Which route would you recommend?

Ask something the listener can answer.

OPTION + REASON

You could take the bus because it stops nearby.

Offer an option with a relevant reason.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the correction: Can you give me an advice?

- A. Can you give me some advices?
- B. Can you give me some advice?
- C. Can you give me a advice?

2. Which question is more focused: What should I do? / Which bus goes to the station?

- A. What should I do?
- B. Which bus goes to the station?
- C. Both questions identify exactly the same problem.

3. What should you do before advising if the deadline is unclear?

- A. Assume the deadline is today.
- B. Recommend the quickest option without asking.
- C. Ask when the person needs to finish or arrive.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. A learner needs a quiet study place. Which exchange gives a relevant option with a reason?

A. I need a quiet place to study. You must go somewhere immediately.

B. I need a quiet place to study. Try the loud music bar because it has live bands.

C. I need a quiet place to study. Where would you suggest? You could try the library because it has a quiet room.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. Can you give me some advice?

Advice is normally uncountable.

2. B. Which bus goes to the station?

It specifies the information needed.

3. C. Ask when the person needs to finish or arrive.

Clarify the missing constraint.

4. C. I need a quiet place to study. Where would you suggest? You could try the library because it has a quiet room.

The question gives the need; the suggestion and reason directly address quiet study.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-44.html